

THE GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT (1 Corinthians 12:1-11)

III. DISCERNING OF SPIRITS

A. In order to group the gifts by threes; revelation gifts; power gifts; utterance gifts; we are going to take the gift of discerning of spirits out of the chronological order in which it is listed in first Corinthians chapter twelve. The revelation gifts are: Word of wisdom, word of knowledge, and discerning of spirits. The study of discerning of spirits will conclude our study of revelation gifts.

Discerning of spirits is the seventh gift listed and can be found in 1 Corinthians 12:10 (NKJV) "*to another the working of miracles, to another prophecy, to another discerning of spirits, to another different kinds of tongues, to another the interpretation of tongues.*"

This gift must not be confused with a critical spirit; analytical ability; telepathy; mind reading; or suspicion. It is in no way a psychic ability, it is in the truest sense of the word a gift that allows our spirit to bear witness with another person's spirit. In the event our spirit does not bear witness, this gift allows us to know what spirit is in operation.

As is the case with all other gifts, *this gift is not given to make us look super-spiritual but allows for a marked advantage in our battle against the enemy by being able to detect the specific spirit behind each attack*, allowing the believer to target a spirit rather than a personality.

This generation has become so enamored with the supernatural and having someone to foresee the future that many so called Christians consult psychics; read their horoscopes; play with ouija boards; and constantly seek out another individual to receive a word about their future. This pursuit includes information about

employment, relationships, health issues, financial obligations, investment strategies, and anything regarding the future.

There is certainly nothing wrong with allowing a person of God to speak into your life, but you better make sure about the character and the spiritual connectedness of the person who is doing the speaking. This is why we feel it is so important to train and screen altar workers.

It is certainly not necessary for the person doing the speaking to be perfect, none of us are, but the source of the word must be from the throne of God, if it is not, it will do far more damage than good.

If a false word is spoken it can alter the course of your life in a very negative way and quite possibly circumvent the destiny God has in mind for you. For instance: If God were calling you to be a banker and a person prophesied to you that God wanted you to be a pastor, if you were not a discerning you may live a frustrated life. Your whole life would be frustrated because you pursued a destiny you weren't called to. In such a case both the individual who received an erroneous word as well as everyone they minister to suffer from the mistake.

A person whose source is not from above could attempt to speak a curse on what God intended to bless.

A good rule of thumb for the revelation gifts is that God will never surprise you with a new word; the word He gives you will only confirm what He has already been speaking into your spirit.

Discerning of spirits allows the believer to be able to detect what kind of spirit or spirits are in operation in any given situation.
(Security at the airport)

This gift is intended to go much further than just simple detection of a spirit, it is intended to;

- Bring the person to a place of repentance
- Correct wrong actions
- Provide a new course of action

B. The word discerning (Greek, diakrisis) means to judge or be able to sort through the evidence, eventually reaching a correct understanding of the facts. The intention of this gift is to be able to look beyond the outward to see that which is not readily apparent in the invisible world of the spiritual, then forming a judgment based on that insight.

This gift is important to every Christian but it is absolutely essential to those who serve in responsible positions of church government.

It cannot be stated too emphatically that this spiritual gift operates only through born again believers. 1 Corinthians 2:14-15 (NKJV) ***"But the natural man does not receive the things of the Spirit of God, for they are foolishness to him; nor can he know them, because they are spiritually discerned.15 But he who is spiritual judges all things, yet he himself is rightly judged by no one."***

This gift is intended for two reasons:

- Detection of demonic spirits operating through unbelievers - One of the unique features of the ministry of Jesus was casting demons out of those who were bound. Legion - Mt. 8 - The dumb man - Mt. 9 - The dumb and blind man - Mt.12 - Little Canaanite girl vexed with a devil whose mother sought Jesus out - Mt. 15 - A young man who is described as a lunatic whose father sought Jesus out (The boy would cast himself in the fire or in the water) - Mt. 17 - Man in the synagogue with an unclean spirit - Mk. 1 - Mary Magdalene

delivered of seven devils - Luke - 8 Casting out evil spirits was also a feature of the apostolic ministry as well as that of the New Testament church - Acts 16:16-18 (NKJV) *"Now it happened, as we went to prayer, that a certain slave girl possessed with a spirit of divination met us, who brought her masters much profit by fortune-telling.17 This girl followed Paul and us, and cried out, saying, "These men are the servants of the Most High God, who proclaim to us the way of salvation."18 And this she did for many days. But Paul, greatly annoyed, turned and said to the spirit, "I command you in the name of Jesus Christ to come out of her." And he came out that very hour."* Casting out demons is supposed to be a feature of the modern day church - Mark 16:15-20 (NKJV) *"And He said to them, "Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature.16 "He who believes and is baptized will be saved; but he who does not believe will be condemned.17 "And these signs will follow those who believe: In My name they will cast out demons; they will speak with new tongues;18 "they will take up serpents; and if they drink anything deadly, it will by no means hurt them; they will lay hands on the sick, and they will recover." 19 So then, after the Lord had spoken to them, He was received up into heaven, and sat down at the right hand of God.20 And they went out and preached everywhere, the Lord working with them and confirming the word through the accompanying signs. Amen."* (Story of young lady in Malvern on a Sunday morning)

- **Detection of demonic spirits attempting to influence Christians** - Let me explain right up front that I do not believe a Christian can be demon possessed, but I do believe Christians can be influenced by demonic spirits. When demonic spirits operate through sinners we call that possession, when they influence Christians we call that oppression. (Explain the difference between possession and

oppression - Afghanistan and the Taliban - The difference in dealing with the two - in possession you cast the devil out - in oppression you cast the spirit down) (My first experience with this was dealing with a young lady who was being vexed by a spirit of infirmity) You don't have to believe me, all you have to do is look at the ministry of Jesus and the Apostles. (1) When James and John saw the rejection of the ministry of Jesus by the people of a Samaritan village they were so angry they attempted to call down fire from heaven to consume the people. Notice how Jesus responds to their actions. [Luke 9:55-56 \(NKJV\)](#) ***"But He turned and rebuked them, and said, "You do not know what manner of spirit you are of."56 "For the Son of Man did not come to destroy men's lives but to save them."*** (2) In Matthew 16 Jesus is telling His disciples of all the things He is about to face and he tells them that in Jerusalem He will suffer reproach, humiliation, and eventually death. Peter can take it no longer and speaks up decrying the words Jesus is speaking. [Matthew 16:22 \(NKJV\)](#) ***"Then Peter took Him aside and began to rebuke Him, saying, "Far be it from You, Lord; this shall not happen to You!"*** Peter is no doubt trying to do a good thing; your motives can be good but your influence from the wrong source! Notice how Jesus responds to Peter. [Matthew 16:23 \(NKJV\)](#) ***"But He turned and said to Peter, "Get behind Me, Satan! You are an offense to Me, for you are not mindful of the things of God, but the things of men."*** (3) Philip, Peter, and John are at Samaria and Simon the sorcerer gets saved! [Acts 8:13 \(NKJV\)](#) ***"Then Simon himself also believed; and when he was baptized he continued with Philip, and was amazed, seeing the miracles and signs which were done."*** In verse 18 he offers the Apostles money for the gift of laying hands on people to receive the gift of the Holy Ghost. [Acts 8:20-24 \(NKJV\)](#) ***"But Peter said to him, "Your money perish with you, because you thought that the gift of God could be***

purchased with money!²¹ “You have neither part nor portion in this matter, for your heart is not right in the sight of God.²² “Repent therefore of this your wickedness, and pray God if perhaps the thought of your heart may be forgiven you.²³ “For I see that you are poisoned by bitterness and bound by iniquity.”²⁴ Then Simon answered and said, “Pray to the Lord for me, that none of the things which you have spoken may come upon me.”

Following is a list of 16 strongholds, and the scripture references to back them up; these strongholds can affect an unbeliever as well as the life and spiritual walk of a believer:

- Stronghold of anti-Christ - 1 John 4:3
- Stronghold of bondage - Romans 8:15
- Deaf and dumb stronghold - Mark 9:17-29
- Stronghold of death - Revelation 20:13-14
- Stronghold of divination - Acts 16:16-18
- Stronghold of error - 1 John 4:6
- Familiar stronghold - Leviticus 19:31
- Stronghold of fear - 2 Timothy 1:7
- Stronghold of haughtiness (pride) - Proverbs 16:18
- Stronghold of heaviness - Isaiah 61:3
- Stronghold of infirmity - Luke 13:11-13
- Stronghold of jealousy - Numbers 5:14
- Stronghold of Lying - 2 Chronicles 18:22
- Stronghold of perversion - Isaiah 19:14
- Stronghold of seduction - 1 Timothy 4:1
- Stronghold of whoredom - Hosea 4:12

The very name of this gift reveals its true character and scope: It is discerning of spirits, not the actions of individuals. This gift reveals the plans, purposes, activities, and manifestations of both the Spirit of God and spirits that are not of God.

This gift reveals the inward activity of demonic forces which would normally escape the recognition of most Christians. (My own experience with anger - Story of young lady in Malvern who saw demons lined up on her curb)

It is extremely important to have this gift operating in your life because the Word reveals that Satan and his ministers would come as wolves dressed in sheep's clothing. 2 Corinthians 11:13-15 (NKJV) *"For such are false apostles, deceitful workers, transforming themselves into apostles of Christ.14 And no wonder! For Satan himself transforms himself into an angel of light.15 Therefore it is no great thing if his ministers also transform themselves into ministers of righteousness, whose end will be according to their works."*

This gift of discerning of Spirits will rip off his mask of deception and expose his devices. Satan hates the manifestation of the gifts of the Spirit; he especially hates the gift of discerning of spirits because it carries with it the ability to thwart his plans even before they have the opportunity to succeed.

C. All previously mentioned spirits can probably be categorized into three categories:

- Holy Spirit
- Evil spirits
- Human spirits

What can be done about these three spirits?

If the Holy Spirit in operation we must do one of two things:

- Get out of the way, allowing Him to do His work
- Obey His instructions

If an evil spirit is in operation we must do one of three things:

- Discern what spirit is in operation

- Pray very specifically against the spirit commanding it to cease its activities
- Cast it out or cast it down depending on whether it is possession or oppression

If a human spirit is in operation we must do the following things;

- Pray for grace to show the kindness of Christ
- Never allow our spirit to become frustrated
- Pray for the individual to adopt the mind of Christ

The mere existence of such a gift as discerning of spirits reveals the real existence of evil and deceiving spirits manifesting themselves through human beings.

As more of God's Spirit is in operation in us, there will be a keener awareness as to the operation of satanic power.

The gift of discerning of spirits, just like the other eight spiritual gifts is not a product of reasoning, or of our natural abilities. God will not entrust this or any of His gifts to serve as a means of entertainment to satisfy the curiosity of carnal Christians. These gifts are not given for personal gain or to satisfy some selfish ambition. God supplies His gifts to accelerate the ministry of imperfect but authentic Christians, who are attempting to minister in an imperfect world.

The preaching of the gospel should go forth with such anointing as to make un-Christ-like spirits uncomfortable. When the gifts of the spirit are in full operation in the church some people will grow increasingly uncomfortable because they sense they are losing their control or they feel they are in danger of being exposed. Demonic spirits will never be able to remain undetected in a spiritual church. Satan wants to covertly operate evil spirits in God's house to do several things;

- To hinder church services
- Sow discord within the body
- Stir up confusion
- Contaminate the pattern of the Christian walk (Making good look evil and evil look good)

PRACTICAL APPLICATION: There may be individuals in this audience who have identified portions of their behavior with these demonic manifestations and as a result you may be concerned about your standing and relationship with God. Because you can identify yourself with some of these demonic manifestations does not necessarily mean you are demon possessed; it could mean that you are being influenced, harassed, or manipulated by one or more of these spirits. I have good news! You can experience freedom in Jesus!

Once you have been made aware of the influence, harassment, and manipulation of the enemy, to persist in those behavior patterns is the equivalent of signaling to that particular spirit to invade your life with all kinds of other vexing problems. If you willingly open the door the tormenting spirits of darkness will attack you without mercy causing you to be weak, discouraged, and defeated.

To allow this gift of discerning of spirits to operate freely in your life the following things will be absolutely necessary:

- Have a personal relationship with Jesus
- Be baptized in the Holy Spirit
- Be a person of prayer
- Be a person of the Word
- Be aware of the spirit world
- Listen to the voice of the Holy Spirit
- Attack the spirit not the person

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(1 Corinthians 12:1-11)

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A. The revelation gifts are: Word of wisdom, word of knowledge, and _____ of _____. 1 Corinthians 12:10

This gift is not given to make us look super-spiritual but allows for a marked _____ in our battle against the enemy by being able to detect the specific spirit behind each _____.

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- Correct wrong _____
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This gift is intended for two reasons:

- Detection of _____ spirits operating through unbelievers
Acts 16:16-18, Mark 16:15-20
- Detection of demonic spirits attempting to influence
Christians Luke 9:55-56, Matthew 16:22, Matthew 16:23,
Acts 8:13, Acts 8:20-24

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2 Corinthians 11:13-15

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